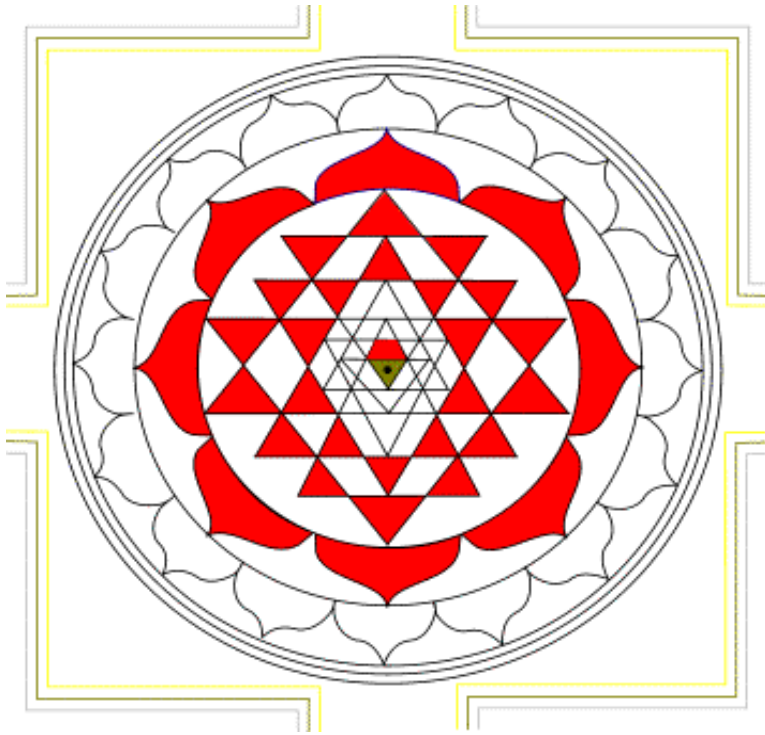


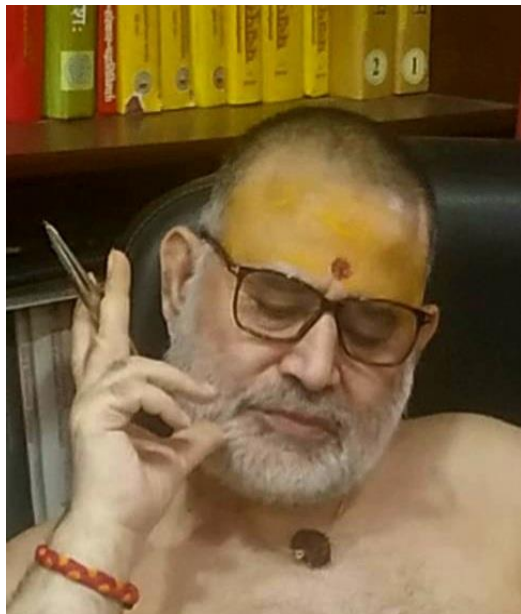


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From the Chief Editor's Desk

All is well that begins well –

Ganesha from a mystic stand point

Quietude predating the creative out-flux has been semiotically attributed to Ganesha .



Completeness and stillness go hand in hand tumult comes from heterogeneity in pervasiveness of consciousness . Hence the simile, like A full moon rising from the milky ocean . The Moon is a produce of churning the milk ocean . A complete whole arising from another whole .The process of such emergence can be only mystical and metaphysical and seldom actual or intellectual, hence the adjective द्वैत-quasi . There cannot be oscillation

and quietude in a single domain . The wave less ocean generates the moon and she in turn oscillates as the expansion of contraction of fifteen digits. The sixteenth digit neither waxes nor wanes . She is the eternal substratum and all other digits rise from her and merge into her . This spontaneity of oscillation is within the perpetual quietude, thus oscillation without movement . There used be a popular style among ancient Sanskrit laureates in which the propitiatory verse had the theme of the entire compilation encrypted in it . The great poet enunciates the mystic and arcane version of – “the famous petite, plump, paunchy, elephant headed but still beautiful “ offspring of Shakti.

While aiming at the luminance of the” rays of the moon of consciousness ether “ चिद्गनचंद्रिका। the ether of consciousness expands in two dimensions vimarsha or word and Prakash the meaning . नादः emanates from the creative flux in the form of word which in this parlance will be the fifteen vowels pertaining to perspective digits of moon or let’s say चिच्चंद्रः consciousness manifested as the moon of consciousness. Nada consolidates into bindu the point of absolute convergence of collective meaning . Since the entity being felicitated is Ganesha the primordial one he manifests as the unison of word and meaning which are yet to separate like cotyledons of a seed in a mode of speech technically called पश्यंती the state when word and meaning or hearing and seeing have just bifurcated.

Another canto felicitating Ganesha in the Nitya tantram is Kal Vinayaka, Ganesha as absolute as well as three dimensional relative time . The beginning’-less and endless being who needs no other entity to establish his raison de etre .

Independence as defined in the Tantra is not needing any other agency for proving the existence - स्वसंविदाकारता and स्वातंत्र्यं go hand in hand .All three realms can be governed only by such entity comprising consolidate self evident consciousness.

Owing to the cyclic propagation of the universal phenomena the beginning and the end converge

at a single point ie the point of time as well as of time transcendence.

So all is well that ends /begins well !

SwamiParanand Tirth

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Editorial



The notion of time and its elusive nature has become more and more prominent in contemporary times. With the advancement of technology and instant information exchange the world has shrunk down into a 'global village'.

The time bound consciousness has a tendency to view progress as a linear development, pandering to the egoistic notions, hence it fails to see the cyclical and playful notion of time. The ancient symbols like 'Ouroboros' (snake/dragon eating its own tail) serve to remind us of the fact that the beginning and end are actually one, its dualistic polarity created by the illusive nature of the phenomena. It is how when a globe is presented as a linear map two places which might be very close indeed appear at two distinct ends.

Since the world is constantly in the state of flux, in the process of 'becoming' it gets very difficult to see the Truth principle underlying the various relative and divergent truths. It is then that a true aspirant prays to Devi to lift the thick veil from her eyes and grant her the vision to see beyond what is visible, comprehend beyond what is comprehensible and assimilate what is beyond assimilation!

Explaining this esoteric notion we begin with the insightful editorial by our Guru Maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirth ji on various arcane metaphorical representations of that infinity which can only be felt by yogic vision. Owing to the cyclic propagation of the universal phenomena the beginning and the end converge at a single point ie the point of time as well as

of time transcendence. So all is well that ends /begins well !

Next we have translation and exposition of 3rd verse of 'Neel Saraswati Stotram' from 'Brihanneel Tantra'. Ma Tara is seen as the personification of bija mantras hreem, kleem and stroom and is praised as manifesting in all the three forms, gross, subtle and causal.

'Mystical Dimensions of Fana and Baqa' is the title of the next scholarly article by Rashneek Kher where he explores the school of Sufism. Explaining the nature of love the author writes, "The heart of the devotee is cleaned via the process of purgation and self-abnegation and this is symbolized by the polishing of the mirror in order to reflect the beauty of the God. However, according to Hallāj, this purification of the heart is not complete without the action of love upon it: and it is love and not intoxication which Hallāj holds to be the supreme path to permanent union with God."

Next we have a thorough academic paper by a young researcher Bhumi Sati on 'The Science of Déjà vu'. Referring to various academic studies and surveys, the author concludes her paper with the the need for future research to look into the importance of contrasting novelty and familiarity in the déjà vu experience.

Following this we have the translation and exposition on two sutras (13th and 14th) of Pratyabhijna Hrdayam by Kshemraj from the YTA study circle. The issue ends with two heartfelt poems capable of invoking strong visual imagery on the notion of love and time by Prof. Ambika Talwar titled 'Love is our immanent soulforce' and 'Transmutation: A world in and beyond times'



(Kimiya)

NEEL SARASWATI STOTRAM

(A Hymn to the sapphire goddess of wisdom from Brihanneel Tantra) Cont.



Semiotic depictions of metaphysical phenomena .

Swami Paranand Tirth

मायानङ्गविकाररूपललनाबिन्द्वर्धचन्द्रात्मिके

हुंफट्कारमयि त्वमेव शरणं मन्त्रात्मिके मादृशः।

मूर्तिस्ते जननि त्रिधामघटिता स्थूलातिसूक्ष्मा परा

वेदनां नहि गोचरा कथमपि प्राप्तां नु तामाश्रये॥ ४

O mother, the personification of mantra comprising Maya [hreem] anang [kleem] vikara rup lalana [stroom] hum phat, I have surrendered to you please behold me .

O mother you manifest in threeforms –gross subtle and causal, even Vedas cannot comprehend you –I have attained you some how and I seek resort in you.

In the arcane lineage of tantricism there is a tradition of encrypting otherwise lofty conceptualisations in aphoristic or discreet syllables called beejakshara.

Here Ma Tara is seen as personification of Hreem, Kleem and Stroom and to firmly establish the identification of the aspirant and Devi mantra Hum Phat, cuts through the narrow individual Ego.

Ha denotes Shiva

Ra denotes Fire

Eem- the most important syllable of Shri kula is called kamkala and is the encryption of the absolute Brahman

Ka signifies the absolute bliss .

La denotes stability or eternity

Eem signifies Kamkala

Sa signifies Moon

Ta signifies Transcendence

Ra signifies Fire

Eem signifies kamkala

Ma manifests in all the three forms gross, subtle and causal and playfully resides in all the phenomenon, seen and unseen, good, bad or ugly, unfathomable to Vedas at times.

She is the one who oscillates and yet is stable. On one hand she is the stillness of the meditative mind on the other she is the intensity of the ecstatic rupture. To know her means to live fully in both the spheres and to realize both are same!



Mystical dimension of Fana and Baqa

Rashneek Kher

The twin words of *Fana* & *Baqa* find numerous mentions in poems of the divine order. The word *Baqa* may not be so much in vogue as its complimentary twin *Fana*. *Fana* is used a lot colloquially in many languages including Persian, Urdu, Kashmiri and of course Arabic, where both the words draw their roots from. *Baqa* on the other hand is used more as conceptual understanding of “that what remains” and although it finds mention in poetry and literature, the use of the word isn’t as widespread as *Fana*.

Very seldom do we even pay heed to where these words come from, what they mean and how deep has their impact been on our spiritual practices. Like any other person, I too was unaware of the larger meaning of these words until one day when we were travelling with Swamiji in Gujarat and he explained in a succinct way the word *Baqa* (from *Baqi*- that what remains). Since then the words, their deeper meanings, their etymological understanding and their metaphysical import has left me bewildered, confused, fascinated and

sometimes just engaged. In my growing up years I would often read Shamas Faqir Kashmiri and a verse that remained with me read-

Vatakhay sukhnan ti gode gach te fani

(The verse will reveal itself, but first annihilate yourself)

The way in which my Guru Maharaj explained the word *Baqa* led me to understand the power of the word, alphabet and the verse.

Ahad Zargar’s almost “heretic” poem, *Harfan Maene Zane Hoshiyar* (The word reveals itself only to the one who is conscious) had assumed a different meaning because of the way Swamiji explained the word *Baqa* to me.

So what exactly do the words *Fana* and *Baqa* mean? Where lies their origin? How did the metaphysicians and the spiritualists understand them are important questions to be asked, contemplated upon and answered but what is more important is how does one realize these concepts and is there a structure somewhere that helps us climb the ladder (if there is one) and stay at the balcony? In this writing we will try and look at the aforementioned aspects of the conceptual understanding of the two “states” (*ahwal*) of a spiritual traveler (*salik*).

Since the source of all Islamic concepts (including the Sufi concepts) comes from The Holy Qur’an we will go to the verse where the twin concepts find their only mention.

The terms fanā’ and baqā’ occur only once in the Qur’an and do so as an interrelated pair. In the middle of the verse of The All Merciful (Surah ar-Raḥmān) the created realm is described as fānin (that which perishes or perishing) whilst the Face of God is described as yabqā (remaining, enduring).¹

All that dwells upon the earth is perishing, yet still

¹ The Dual Mystical Concepts of Fana’ and Baqa’ in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

abides the Face of thy Lord, majestic, splendid²

If we read through the verse, we understand the ephemeralness of the worldly existence and the eternal nature of the supreme creator. This beautiful verse has set off an entire school of metaphysics and the message resounds subtle and sublime & yet immensely powerful. We should seek that which is permanent and move away from that what is temporary or transient.

It is generally believed that Abu Saad Ahmad Isa Al-Kharraz(d 899) was the first to use these terms as specific and interrelated terms but the terms were already in vogue especially with mystics like Bayazid Bistami(d 874 or 848).The earliest Sufis believed that these were the “highest” stages of spiritual development and had developed the methods(*tariqa*) that a traveler (*Salik*) should follow to go through the various stations(*maqamat*). It was also believed that these stages are achieved by the strivings of the devotee but may sometimes be accompanied by the onset of certain psychological states(*ahwal*) in the form of divine grace.

The principle of divine unity is described as “The Central Mystery of Islam” by Annemarie Schimmel in her book, *Mystical Dimensions of Islam*. Our understanding of the terms Fana and Baqa will thus emanate from our indulgence and understanding of the central concept of *tawhid* or divine unity. The concept of one God who is absolute and has no equal or parallel and is the only one who has agency is **unique** to Islam. There are many verses in the Holy Book which reinforce the concept of One God and that One God Being Omnipotent, Omnipresent and Omniscient.

Egyptian Dhu’n Nun al-Misri (d.859) says:

Tawhīd is that you know that God’s omnipotence in the calling into being of anything does not result necessarily from a natural power, and that His creation goes on without instrument; that the cause of all things is His creation which has no cause and that everything which you, yourself, may form a conception of is a thing, so that God is different from it. ³

The lack of human agency or any agency for that matter makes the Sufi ask a pertinent question. How does “she or he” perform any actions on the path of God knowing that they are “his or her” actions when “she or he” is fully aware of “his or her” un-agency? It is this dichotomy or paradox that the doctrines of Fana and Baqa respond to.

*Hujwiri states that Kharraz was the first to develop an explanation of the states of annihilation and subsistence, defining fanā’ as the ‘annihilation of consciousness of manhood (‘ubūdiyyat)’ and baqā’ as ‘subsistence in the contemplation of Godhead (ilāhiyyat).’Hujwiri interprets the term manhood (servanthood) here as agency in one’s actions, thus fanā’ is the destruction of the illusion that one’s actions are one’s own and baqā’ is the experiential realization that one’s actions (indeed all actions) belong to God’s agency alone.*⁴ It is significant to note that both annihilation and subsistence here are states of awareness and not ontological states.⁵

Andrew Wilcox states that the most definite definition of *tawhid* has been elaborated by Junayd, one of the greatest masters of Sufi doctrine.

Unification is the separation of the Eternal from that which was originated in time.

So, to unify with the eternal, one (one’s consciousness) has to separate from the temporal. Two processes have to happen almost in a linear or simultaneous manner? Separation from the illusory thus unreal material world and unification with the true immortal universal being. In the course of our writing, we will come to know whether these processes have to be linear or simultaneous.

Among the earliest mystics of Sufism was a certain Abu Yazid (Bayazid) of Bistam who is believed to have introduced the term *Fana* into Sufi lexicon. His mystical utterances called *Shathiyat* openly proclaimed of saying “Glory be to me” *Subhani* instead of *Subhan Allah* – “Glory be to God”. Naturally most orthodox Muslims found his *shath* to be heretic in nature and not in consonance with the Islamic practice. However,

² *The Koran Interpreted* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998) – Arberry A.J

³ *The Koran Interpreted* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998) – Arberry A.J

⁴ Hujwiri, *Kashf al- Mahjūb* p.245,246,281

⁵ Abdel-Kader, *The Life, Personality and Writings of al-Junayd*, p. 70.

Bistami explained this and other utterances by saying that any duality even in linguistics ran the risk of polytheism (*shirk*). Although he did not leave any written works behind yet his followers collected and compiled almost five hundred *shaths*.

*Whilst these quotations do not constitute a systematic theory of fanā' they are important because they figuratively relay Bayazid's personal experiences and portray a mystic's journey towards the goal of consciousness of the Unity of God (tawhīd) through the annihilation of his awareness of self (fanā')*⁶

We will look at one of his *shath* to understand the concepts of *Fana* and *Baqa* as he himself understood them or wanted others to understand them. This is from "The Book of Flashes by Abu Nasr As-Sarraj".

Once [God] raised me up and placed me before him, and said to me:
'O Abu Yazid, verily my creation longs to seek thee.'
I said: "Adorn me with thy unity and clothe me in thine I-ness and raise me up unto thy oneness, so that when the creatures see me, they may say:
'We have seen thee and thou are *that*.' **Yet I (Bistami) will not be there at all**

Through this verse Bayazid describes the process of *Fana*. He conveys how Bayazid found *tawhid* (oneness with God) by clothing in his thyness and thus there is no Bayazid anymore (*Baqa*).

The analogy of clothing in "his" attributes finds myriad mentions in Sufi poems across the spectrum. Swach Kral a 20th century Sufi poet of Kashmir asks his master

Shall I clothe thee, and the Master replies, The Lord Alone Can clothe me

The "arrival" of the Sufi is denoted by shunning his previous clothes (attributes) thus the stage of "*Fana*", and the donning of the eternal dress is "*Baqa*".

There is no doubt that Bistami was one of the foremost Sufis to have elucidated the concept of *Fana* and *Baqa* yet many of his critics believe that he did not get rid of duality and the self-doubt. There are verses where he mentions of him and God being separate entities. Whatever be the case Bayazid of Bistami remains a

towering figure and a pioneer among the Sufis especially among those who wish to achieve the lofty concepts of *Fana* & *Baqa*.

*Aqal ka Madrasa & Ishq Ka Mehqada*⁷

It seems paradoxical that we are talking of schisms in the realm of unity. Maybe these schisms did not really matter to the masters themselves yet for a layman to understand and choose a path, they have to be understood as they came down to us. Many Sufi poets especially in our part of the world use the image of an intoxicated mendicant as the ideal mystic. From Baba Bulleh Shah's –*Mae Jaana Jogi De Naal* to Zaheen Shah Taji's – *Tune Deewana Banaya*, the ideal mystic is intoxicated by the essence of Godliness and often immersed in world which goes beyond the approved norms of the society. His utterances and attire are often akin to that of a *Majnun* (a mad man). Many a times these poets had to face the wrath of orthodoxy and often ended up explaining their point of view to clear the fog around the utterances. A Kashmiri poet Ahad Zargar uttered – *She who suckled you, is the one who you should wed-And that is union (as prescribed)*.

So from a historical perspective we are dealing with two schools of Sufis, one called The School of Sobriety (*sahw*) also known as The School of Baghdad and another called The School of Intoxication (*sukr*), known as The School of Khorasan. The fundamental point of contention between these two apparently contradicting schools of thought is regarding the ultimate goal of *Fana*. The former believes that at the apex of mystical union the Sufi is no longer the person he is in the worldly realm, so even his utterances are not his own because he is intoxicated by the mystical union. The latter however believes that even at the height of the mystical union the mystic is a model for the community and the world at large and thus her or his conduct cannot be contrary to that of Islamic Law (*Sha'ria*). This schism between the Sufi at an esoteric and an exoteric world leads to conflicting worldview of the two schools.

In this part of the world the Intoxicated school has held sway and most Sufi poets have spoken of Mansur bin Hallaj as the ultimate intoxicated Sufi. Hundreds, nay

⁶ The Dual Mystical Concepts of Fana' and Baqa' in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

⁷ Shah Niyaz Barelvi –Aqal ke madrasay se uth Ishq ke mahqade ma e aa.

thousands of poems invoke Mansur as he finds calling across cultures, languages and even ethnic landscapes. Sufis almost idolize him and even the common man finds resonance with his expressions. That makes it imperative for us to understand and comprehend the masters of the other school – The School of Sobriety. Abul Qasim al-Junayd was largely believed to be one of the most well-known proponents of this school. Annemarie Schimmel describes him as follows:

*The undisputed master of the Sūfīs of Baghdad was Abu'l-Qasim al-Junayd, who is considered the pivot in the history of early Sufism. The representatives of divergent mystical schools and modes of thought could refer to him as their master, so that the initiation chains of later Sūfī orders almost invariably go back to him.*⁸

Junyad did not reveal the esoteric concepts to the common masses and kept the initiation limited strictly to his trusted disciples. Since the worldview of this school mentions that the Mystical masters have to be role models to the society their conduct in public was measured and often little was said about esotericism and more emphasis was laid on Sharia although the inner circle was abuzz with the light of the Lord.

It was Junyad who describes the path(*tariqa*) to the state of *fana*. He talks about three stages of purgation. The first stage is the purgation of desire, the second being the purgation of pleasure and is brought about by acts of self-abnegation on the part of the devotee and third and the final stage is the purgation of the consciousness of self as an individual. At every stage of purgation, a devotee is ridding herself of the human attributes and rising a ladder so to say but only when she arrives at the final or the third stage of *Fana* does she truly attain the highest mystical state of *Fana*. Such a state is called *Fana-al-Fana-the passing away of the state of awareness of the state of annihilation*. It is emphasized- *That your physical being continues but your individuality has departed.*⁹ From a superficial understanding one can feel that the human endeavor or effort leads to the state of *Fana-al-Fana* but if we delve

a little more especially at what happens at the third stage of purgation the “divine hand” comes into play and among Sufis it is believed that the grace of the Lord bestows this state upon an individual. *As such the process of purgation is the result of human activity whereas the mystical state is ultimately a grace of God*¹⁰. The mystic witnesses (*shahadat*) the reality of *Tawhid* because she/he understands that God alone has agency.

Since this school believes that esotericism is not for the masses they often communicated with their disciples through signals (*isharat*). Nowhere is this more evident that when he goes on to describe *Baqa-* the complementary state of *Fana*.

*He has Fana, and this too is obliterated, because he persists in Baqa, only through complete obliteration*¹¹.

So the overwhelming of the individual self by the attributes of God is *baqa* and in this state there is no awareness, even of the state of *Fana*. Thus the two states are in a way similar or even same but from different points of view. What is interesting from the standpoint of this school is that it places limits on human personality so much so that even when one is in the state of *Baqa*, he is still not identical with God. There is therefore no merging of essences (*ittiḥād*) and no incarnation of God in man (*ḥulūl*), the process is therefore an experiential witnessing not an ontological becoming¹². The standpoint of this school is that the man has to return to its primordial covenant which is to say that a man has to return to the original state of mankind. This concept of *Mithaq* establishes the master-servant relationship between the God and the man. Junayd goes on to say that in this existence before creation their state was an existence through God where they were conscious of God alone and unaware of self.

This thought finds eloquent mention in Wahab Khar's poem.

Tale oss adam bood gachanay, tas te mae aaes zaan

⁸ Schimmel, *Mystical Dimensions*, p. 57.

⁹ Abdel-Kader, *The Life, Personality and Writings of al-Junayd*, p. 81.

¹⁰ The Dual Mystical Concepts of *Fana'* and *Baqa'* in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

¹¹ Abdel-Kader, *The Life, Personality and Writings of al-Junayd*, p. 89

¹² The Dual Mystical Concepts of *Fana'* and *Baqa'* in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

Aade lodun, Jannat, kabe-jahanam, baye bhutkhanay

Much before he(God) created Paradise, Hell and the House of Idolaters
Even Before he conceived Adam, I was aware of Him(alone)

The School of Sobriety does not believe in any excesses. The school reaffirms that excess is imperfection and thus intoxication even of the mystical kind is defective and thus leads to partial annihilation and not complete annihilation. Junayd describes Bayazid's experiences as only 'one stretch along the path' and not the most advanced inner essence that those who are called are capable of¹³

In the Junaydean worldview Mansur Bin Hallaj is presented as a mystic who has lost his way. However, if we look at any other sources of knowledge on the subject we see Hallaj as a martyr who sacrificed himself at the altar of the faith, thereby standing out as a mystic who put into practice the complete theory of annihilation. Shibli is given to say '[m]y madness saved me, whereas his lucidity destroyed him'¹⁴ indeed Massignon goes so far as to say that, '[a]fter the sixth/twelfth century, no Muslim mystic disavowed Hallaj'¹⁵.

In his utterance of "Anal-Haq" which could be translated as "I am Truth" therefore "I am God" he went a step ahead of Bistami. This utterance brings into focus The School of Intoxication whose hero was the enigmatic Hallaj. However, a deeper reading of Hallaj makes us understand that while he did not defend the primacy of intoxication, he discounts both Sobriety and Intoxication insufficient for sustained union with God.

*O Master, sobriety (ṣaḥw) and intoxication (sukr) are only the two human aspects of the mystic, who remains separated from his Lord as long as these two aspects are not both annihilated*¹⁶

Hallāj proposes that although the attributes of the mystic are annihilated in Divine Union ('*ayn al-jam'*), his essential personality remains but is connected and harmonized with the Divine Will. Mansur's concept of *Isqat-al-wasa'it* –the disappearance of means when the ends are achieved should not bother or think too deeply of the methods or means through which the union is achieved and should not consider them as ends in itself. Thus Mansur rises above both schools and talks of *tawhid* as "Annihilation of Separation" *tafrid*¹⁷. Therein lies the difference between his concept of *tawhid* and that of Junayd's. Junayd emphasizes that *tawhid* requires separation but Hallaj talks of annihilation of separation and here he brings the concept of heart as the organ of mystical perception.

The heart of the devotee is cleaned via the process of purgation and self-abnegation and this is symbolized by the polishing of the mirror in order to reflect the beauty of the God. However, according to Hallāj, this purification of the heart is not complete without the action of love upon it: and it is love and not intoxication which Hallāj holds to be the supreme path to permanent union with God¹⁸. Before the emergence of Hallaj as a thought leader among Sufis, the love of the God was synonymous with obedience but Hallaj talked of reciprocal & passionate love (*ishq*).

Baba Bhulleh Shah Says- *Tere Ishq Nachaya kar ke thaya thaya* (Your love drove me into an eternal trance)

To Hallāj the Sūfī is a witness or '*shāhid*, the proof of love' and '[t]he inner reality of love is that you remain always with your Beloved and strip off your own qualities'¹⁹. The word *Ishq* can have many meanings but among the followers of Hallaj, Shibli says it is an agent of *Fana*. Thus, the mystical love of God when fully developed is a selfless devotion to the will of the Beloved for the sake of God through surrendering unto God²⁰. One is tempted to ask if there is the lover and the

¹³ . Abdel-Kader, *The Life, Personality and Writings of al-Junayd*, p. 220

¹⁴ Massignon, *The Passion of al-Hallaj*: p 105

¹⁵ Massignon, *The Passion of al-Hallaj*: p 107

¹⁶ Massignon, *The Passion of al-Hallaj*: p 117

¹⁷ Herbert Mason, "Hallāj and the Baghdad School of Sufism" *The Heritage of Sufism*, Vol 1. ed. Leonard Lewisohn (Oxford: Oneworld, 1999), p. 72.

¹⁸ The Dual Mystical Concepts of Fana' and Baqa' in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

¹⁹ Al-Qushayri, *Principles of Sufism*, trans. B. R. Von Schlegell (Berkeley: Mizan Press, 1992), p. 332.

²⁰ The Dual Mystical Concepts of Fana' and Baqa' in early Sufism- Andrew Wilcox

beloved, isn't this duality. Hallaj answers this by what Massignon has interpreted as "mystical exchange of wills".

"the amorous nuptial in which the Creator ultimately rejoins his creature, in which He embraces him and in which the latter opens his heart to his Beloved in intimate, familiar, burning, and flowing discourse"

The above verse leaves little to imagination because it lays bare that the heart of the lover receives *ishq* from the beloved. This thought inspired hundreds of Sufis and later day poets like Amir Khusrau, Baba Bhuleh Shah and Allama Iqbal have written verses which speak in their own words about the lover and the beloved, the passage through the heart and intense burning of love.

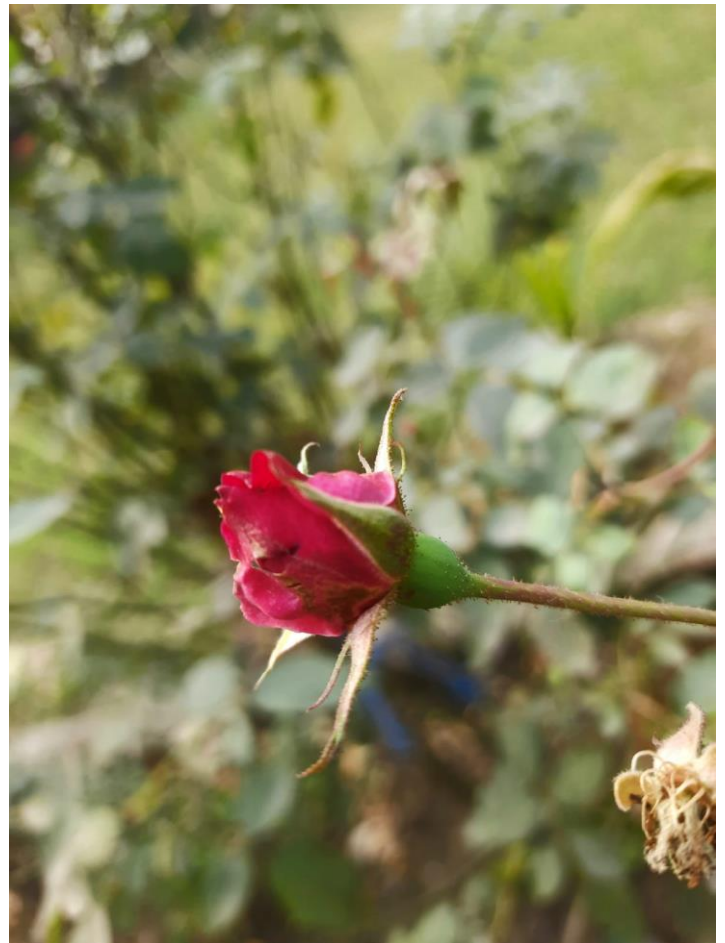
Shamas Faqir Kashmiri says

How do I tell you, what I saw?
I burned (by) the intensity of love,
And that's what I saw.

It was unfortunate that his teachings and utterances were not understood by the orthodoxy of the time and he was sentenced to death for heresy but even in that Mansur relishes the thought of dying for faith and love. I finish this small note by quoting Mansur himself and leaving it to the reader's imagination of what *Fana* and *Baqā* eventually means to each one of us.

I am a metaphor (of God conveyed to man), not a generic kinship (of God with man), an apparition (of God), not an infusion (ḥulūl) in a material receptacle. My (present) survival [baqā'] is not a (mere) return to pre-eternity; it is a reality that is imperceptible to the senses and beyond the reach of analogies.

(Rashneek Kher is a Kashmiri poet and a literary critic living in exile in Faridabad)





The Science of Déjà Vu

Bhumi Sati

Have you ever had the odd feeling that you have gone through the same thing exactly before and had a prediction associated with it? It may occasionally even feel as though you are reliving a past event. The sensation of déjà vu is brief and frequently unexpected, which is why we equate it with mystery and even the paranormal.

Many theories on what can trigger déjà vu, French for "previously seen", started to surface in the late 1800s. People speculated that it might be caused by mental illness or some brain disorder, or perhaps there was a brief blip in the generally smooth working of human memory. People also reported cases of prediction after experiencing such feelings of déjà vu. For a very long time, déjà vu has baffled philosophers, neurologists, and writers alike. But it took a long time for the subject

to enter the world of science. Nevertheless, many theories about déjà vu have developed in recent years as more scientists have started researching this phenomenon, indicating that it may not simply be a memory system defect in our brains. In a study²¹ Colorado State University psychologist Anne M. Cleary discusses recent research on déjà vu, including the many parallels between déjà vu and prediction. The book "The Déjà Vu Experience" by Dr. Alan Brown²² served as an inspiration for Cleary. In his work, Brown urged researchers to use the most recent approaches and models to assess the validity of the many déjà vu ideas.

Déjà vu and Prediction

Furthering her research about déjà vu, Cleary and Claxton, in their 2021 research¹, discussed déjà vu and premonition. Early studies on cerebral stimulation by Wilder Penfield contain a report of an association between these two sensations. The researchers described a scenario when a patient was neurologically stimulated in the medial temporal lobe region, after which the patient claimed to have experienced both déjà vu and an intense feeling of what was to come thereafter²³. Recent research by Cleary and Claxton²⁴ established the first verifiable link between perceptions of déjà vu and premonition-like feelings.

Thirty students from Colorado State University took part in this research (Experiment 1). Study-test blocks were composed of 16 movies and 32 videos. Half of each block's 32 test scenes corresponded to one of the 16 study scenes before them. In the test conditions, participants watched videos of new scenes. They were

²¹ Anne M. Cleary, Katherine L. McNeely-White, Andrew M. Huebert & Alexander B. Claxton (2021) Déjà vu and the feeling of prediction: an association with familiarity strength, *Memory*, 29:7, 904-920, DOI: 10.1080/09658211.2018.1503686

²² Brown, A.S. (2004). *The Déjà Vu Experience* (1st ed.). Psychology Press. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203485446>

²³ Mullan, S., & Penfield, W. (1959). Illusions of comparative interpretation and emotion: Production of epileptic discharge and by

electrical stimulation in the temporal cortex. *A.M.A. Archives of Neurology and Psychiatry*, 81, 269–284. <https://doi.org/10.1001/archneurpsyc.1959.02340150001001>

²⁴ Cleary, A. M., & Claxton, A. B. (2018). Déjà vu: An illusion of prediction. *Psychological Science*, 29(4), 635–644. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0956797617743018>

to say whether the test scene reminded them of anything after watching each video on the test. After the test, they were asked how frequently they got déjà vu, in general.

Cleary and Claxton discovered it was reported that there were

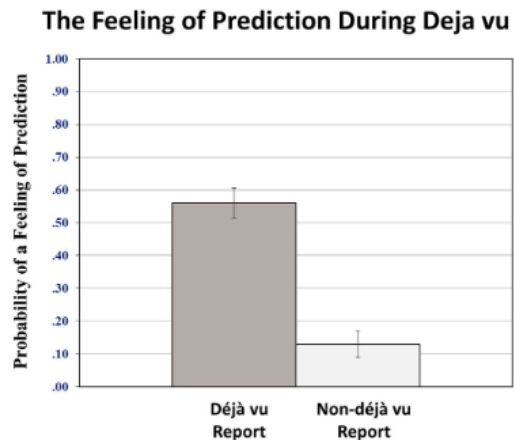


Figure 1: The association between déjà vu reports and feelings of prediction, which was originally shown by Cleary and Claxton.

considerably stronger sensations of prediction during reported déjà vu states than during reported non-déjà vu states using a modification of a memory model that they had adopted from Cleary et al.²⁵ Another curious point was dwelt upon: "*whether a similarly drawn path of navigation, through the same layout of an otherwise new test scene would result in any actual predictive ability during déjà vu in cases of retrieval failure (forgetting from long term memory)*". It was found that showing the same layout of the scene increases the likelihood of déjà vu reports during retrieval failure.

The nature of this association and the reasons behind it are still unknown, despite the fact that Cleary and Claxton's (2018) work is the first concrete demonstration of a connection between déjà vu experiences and feelings of premonition. According to

their theory, the individual who experiences déjà vu may believe the entire current occurrence is just about to be retrieved from memory. This may be similar to how the participant's "**tip-of-the-tongue state**" feels as though the unrecalled word is just about to be remembered. In the case of déjà vu, however, it may feel more like one is on the verge of an experience, as if a full familiarity with the current scenario is about to be brought to mind. The participants said to be accompanied by sensations of prediction in almost half of the cases. This implies that the sensation of premonition is neither a requirement for reporting having déjà vu nor is it the only feature that characterises the phenomenon. The next experiment of this study talked about déjà vu and familiarity.

Déjà vu and Familiarity

In a second study (Experiment 2), forty-four students from Colorado State University took part in an experiment on déjà vu and familiarity.

The procedure was the same as in Experiment 1, except that participants were now asked whether the scene generated a sense of familiarity.

When déjà vu occurred, the "I knew that was

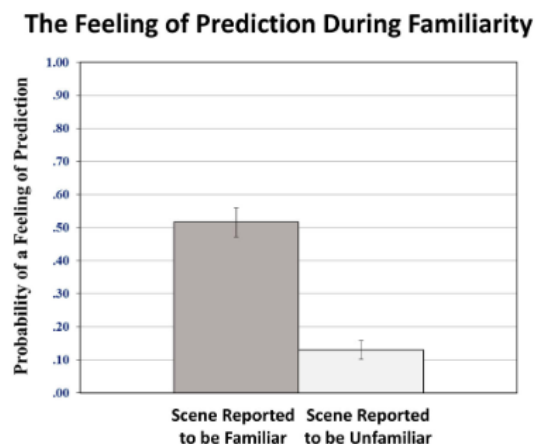


Figure 2: The probability of reporting a feeling of prediction was greater among scenes that were reported be familiar than among scenes that were reported to be unfamiliar.

²⁵ Cleary A. M., Brown A. S., Sawyer B. D., Nomi J. S., Ajoku A. C., Ryals A. J. (2012). Familiarity from the configuration of objects in 3-

dimensional space and its relation to déjà vu: A virtual reality investigation. *Consciousness and Cognition*, 21, 969–975.

going to happen" bias was high, and it was extreme when the scene was judged as being extremely familiar. The possibility of experiencing a sense of prediction increases with the degree of situational familiarity. Reports of feelings of prediction were generally more prevalent when scenes were described as familiar than when they were described as unknown, and they were also linked to high familiarity intensity. We summarise from these trends that people's high familiarity with many déjà vu-inducing circumstances leads them to believe that they know what will happen next.

While talking about familiarity, neuroscience concepts can also be linked to it. Dr. Fisher, says that the temporal lobe experiences seizures that cause feelings and a sense of familiarity that are disconnected from the outside world. Our 'rational' brain strives to make sense of these contradictory signals, which causes us to experience both familiar and foreign sensations simultaneously. Hence, this is how neuroscience can explain these concepts.

While these two experiments are interesting, many more fields could be ventured into in the future. Any theories on causality are still theories at this point because the data offered here mostly show existing interrelationships among déjà vu reports, feelings of prediction, and feelings of familiarity. Further studies should elaborate on how variables like familiarity intensity, déjà vu, and sensations of prediction interact. The test scenes in this paradigm are all novel, yet because of their resemblance to instances, some of them might also appear familiar. Thus, in the test phase of the paradigm, novelty and familiarity are contrasted. Although this contrast or juxtaposition fits the typical definition of déjà vu, it is still unclear how important it is to the déjà vu experience from a scientific standpoint. Hence, future research should also look into the importance of contrasting novelty and familiarity in the déjà vu experience.

(Bhumi Sati is pursuing higher studies in Psychology from Concordia University, Montreal, Canada)



Pratyabhijna made easy 13th and 14th Aphorism

Sutra: Tat parijsane chittam ev antarmukhi bhaven
Chaitanya padahyaro hat chiti

Translation: By the knowledge of ones being the
agency of carrying out the five functions like
Parameshwara the Chittam itself gets introvert and
ascends the path of consciousness to become chiti.

Exposition:

The previous sutra explains the phenomena from the
stand point of prameya or Objectivity. This sutra
explains the same from the perspective of literal
consistency.

By the knowledge that the aspirant like the
Parmeshwara carries out the five functions, one
ceases to be deluded by one's own shaktis and
attains unison with one's eternally free essential
nature.

Chittam or the mind of an empirical experient is
nothing else but divergent and conditioned chiti or
consciousness. It becomes extrovert due to
conditioning. The knowledge of one's capacity to
carry out the five-fold functions reverses the process.
The mind gets introvert and ascends to the state of
subjective consciousness and becomes chiti- which is
nothing but its own transcendental conscious state.
A question arises, if the absolute state of Chit Shakti
assimilates all differences by its very virtue then this
virtue should be same even in the state of maya. Like
the sun covered in a flake of cloud also illuminates
its presence- This phenomena has been explained in
the next sutra

Questions:

1. Chittam gets introvert and ascends to the state of
consciousness to become chiti as it

1. Gets introvert
2. Knows ones own doership of the five functions
3. 1 & 2
4. None of these

2. The chit or pure consciousness is the essential
nature of chittam and thus that of the aspirant

1. Yes
2. No
3. Can't say
3. The nature of chiti is not mitigated even as it

descends to the states of maya

1. True
2. False

Sutra: Chiti vahini avarohapade chhanoapi matraya
meyendhanam plusyati

Translation: The fire of consciousness proceeding
towards the state of maya paramata even as concealed
or covered burns down the fuel of objectivity,
partially though

Exposition:

1. The Fire and Consciousness

Consciousness and chiti is comparable to fire since it
burns down all objectivity. Here it does not allude to
Chidagni or the conscious fire as chit Shakti is
described in agamas. Here consciousness has been
depicted as fire in a semiotic manner. As an
engulfing fire chit Shakti burns down the fuel of
objectivity and hence burns down the entire
universal phenomena

2. Veiling of her nature

She remains the same even as she descends to the
state of maya paramata and gets veiled in objectivity.
This veiling is not compulsive but deliberate, owing
to the independent disposition of chiti even in veiling
her essential nature. She veils herself like fire
concealed in a heap of ash.

3. Burning down the fuel of objective phenomena

Burning down has been defined by Kshemraj as
assimilation. The fire of consciousness assimilates
the objectivity like the varieties of blue, yellow etc.
but not entirely, a part of it remains in a dormant
causal form or sanskara and sprouts again. It is a
matter of common experience that all experients
assimilate the objectivity. This has been enunciated
by Utpaladevacharya in his hymn,
"All beings even Indra and Vishnu etc abide in the
lord as – being engulfed, therefore I adore the
universe as the embodiment of the lord who
manifests as the universe"

The next sutra explains how an aspirant attains
unison with the agency of creation, sustenance etc.
after withdrawing the divergence of the goddesses of
sense perceptions.

Questions

1. The fire of consciousness is literally the fire

- 1 no
- 2 yes
- 3 can't say

.

2. Even as veiled छन्नोपि refers to

- 1 deliberate
- 2 enforced
- 3 virtual
- 4 Types of veiling .

3. Is the Burning down

- 1 partial
- 2 entire
- 3 successive

4. What is meant by a matter of common experience

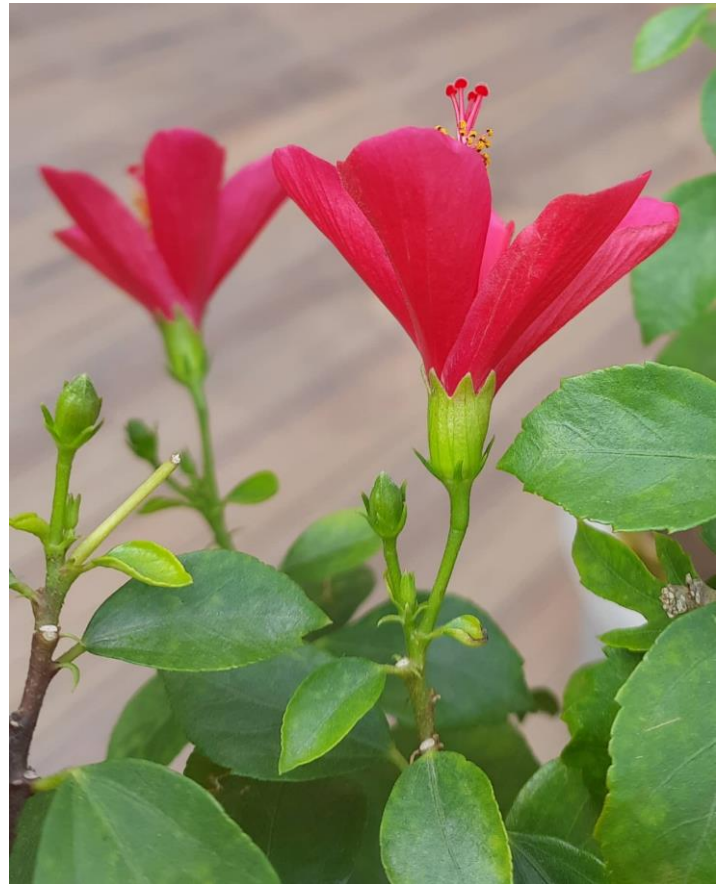
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- 1 experiencer always assimilates objectivity
- 2 experiencer assimilates objectivity sporadically
- 3 experiencer is assimilated in objectivity

5. The universal manifestation of parameshwara being facilitated appears as devouring all demigod like Indra vishnu etc .

- 1 true
- 2 false
- 3 can't say .

6. Explain avaroh padam .(The state of descending)
in five sentences





Love is Our Immanent Soul Force

~ Ambika Talwar

Lotus petals swirl into
a whorl fragrant in water
bee lands for nectar *Gaia's children we*
 ache to emerge
 long to return Bird weaves
Time's Tapestry...
 threads of light awaken darkness
 with a hymn
Precious tender baby
freedom is divine virtue
closer than patience
attainable without, it births within *You are here*
 all these years limitless
 in all directions
 we await Our love.

Precious new world! We have climbed mountains, swallowed poisons, and burned in test of fire.
To take care of you, we ask what you need. ... Shall we be *Spanda*, harmonic golden weave of
dynamic vibration – shall we be *amrit* for beloveds to unite?

May we become the becoming!

Heart's a rainbow sutra
warmed by Sun's impartial eyes
Love's blanket is surrender to Soul Force



Note: *Spanda* – Sanskrit for cosmic vibration or “pulse” that brings into form and is *nada* (a level of sound that is supreme animating highest reality). * *Amrit* – Sanskrit for beyond death as manna of immortality & longevity. * *Sutra* – Sanskrit for thread – literally.

Transmutation: A World In & Beyond Time
~ Ambika Talwar

*Tenderness...of a delicate flower
is like baby's fingers in our hands
passing breeze whispers nothing
simplicity marks soil intelligences...*

A world without time is a world beyond imagination.
How shall it come into form and substance?
Time is a weave of beginnings and endings –
Is the latter wrongly named? Can endings not
be drummer's fingers moving rapidly ...
transmutation like desire into sound ceaseless

manifesting into blossoms for *sakura* – or that time
when you held my gaze and I became a swan;
I tried to fly, but my wings turned to
gossamer gold light – done by your magic.

Endings may not be – but time is a spell.
Butterfly lives for a few moments once the imaginal
the gooey mush of life has occurred in stages –
sticky stuff coming undone into a whole new being.
Wings of time some say: Beauty falls as powder on

green grass through which sprints speedy wind –
must have somewhere to visit. A waiting waif.
Borning comes and borning goes into element,
form, texture. A melody surges into silence
whose notes like tendrils leave us enrapt – no end.

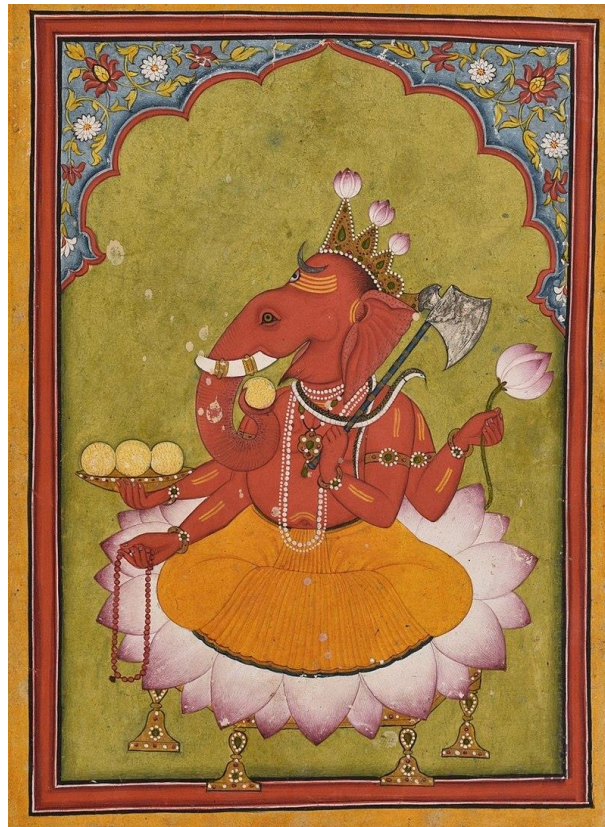
My eyes shift to see and recall how you
mimic each moment a mirror of my soul's longings.

Love's transmutations envelope the cosmos
through empty and broken hearts – so timeless a weave
in shades of time – every moment a singular beauty!



Note: *Sakura* is a Japanese spring festival with peach blossoms

(Ambika Talwar is an India-born author, poet, wellness consultant, artist, and educator whose vision is to realize her sacred destiny and invite others to brilliance. She has authored *4 Stars and 25 Roses* (poems for her father) and *My Greece: Mirrors & Metamorphoses* about her travels through Greece in 2002.)



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ganesha#/media/File:Ganesha_Basohli_miniature_circa_1730_Dubost_p73.jpg



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